Why I am opposed to assisted suicide and euthanasia

Articulate and persuasive arguments against legalising assisted suicide and euthanasia have been expressed by a broad range of individuals and organisations from diverse perspectives, professional backgrounds, political views and life experiences.

The thirteen articles collected here give a sampling of opinion pieces from indigenous leaders (Pat Dodson), disability activists (Stella Young), journalists (Paul Kelly), human rights lawyers, (Julian McMahon), academics (Richard Stith, Kevin Yuill), former and serving politicians (Paul Keating, John Anderson and Dominic Perrottet), palliative care physicians (Adrian Dabscheck), oncologists (Ian Haines) and medical organisations (American College of Physicians, World Medical Assembly).

From this diversity of perspectives there emerges a common view that legalising assisted suicide or euthanasia can never be done safely.

Firstly the very act of legalisation is premised, as Paul Keating eloquently explains on a decision that "*there will be people whose lives we honour and those we believe are better off dead*".

Secondly the claim to establish a "*safe*" regime of assisted suicide (in each jurisdiction claimed to be the very safest in the world!) is premised on a "*bald utopianism*" that deliberately ignores the reality that "*no law and no process*" can prevent wrongful deaths as evidenced in each of the thirty jurisdictions which have tried this experiment to date.

Senator Pat Dodson



Speaking as a Labor senator for Western Australia and as a Yawuru man, Pat Dodson opposed a bill that would have given the Australian territories a power to legalise assisted suicide and euthanasia.

We exist not as solitary individuals; we exist within a family, a community, our cultures and ethos, and in the kinship landscape. I'm a great admirer of those who have cared for loved ones and made personal sacrifices to do so. Not everyone is able to do this, I know, and I do not condemn them for the choices that they make. In the broad sense, we are part of a common humanity. If we give one person the right to make that decision—that is, to assist in committing suicide—we as a whole are affected. If we give one family that right, we as a whole are affected. If we give one state or territory that right, we as a country are affected. If we give one nation the right to determine life, our common humanity is affected. I cannot support this legislation.



Stella Young

The late Stella Young, comedian, writer and disability activist, wrote on the implications of legalising assisted suicide for people living with disabilities:

Social attitudes towards disabled people come from a medical profession that takes a deficit view of disability. This is my major concern with legalising assisted death; that it will give doctors more control over our lives. As a disabled person who has had a lot to do with the medical profession, I can tell

you that this is the space in which I've experienced some of the very worst disability prejudice and discrimination. Doctors might know about our biology, but it doesn't mean they know about our lives.

Paul Kelly

Respected author and journalist Paul Kelly writes:



The justification for euthanasia lies in human rights, individual autonomy and relieving pain — all worthy ideas, and that may prompt the question: why then is euthanasia still opposed by most nations, most medical professional bodies around the world and the Australian Medical Association?

The reason is not hard to find. It is because crossing the threshold to euthanasia is the ultimate step in medical, moral and social terms. A polity is never the same afterwards and a society is never the same. It changes forever the doctor-patient bond. It is because, in brutal but honest terms, more people will be put at risk by the legislation than will be granted relief as beneficiaries.

Julian McMahon



Julian McMahon AC, 2016 Victorian of the Year, barrister, human rights advocate and fierce opponent of the death penalty warns that legalising assisted suicide "*immediately places the elderly sick, and the most vulnerable under intolerable pressures. Over time, despite its intent to assist a few rational people to die, the changes in attitude it signals will undermine society's support for the lives of the voiceless and those most in need. It should be rejected*."

Richard Stith



Law professor Richard Stith warns that "*A culture of disdain for disabled and elderly persons is more likely to come about if we embrace a right to assisted suicide. Each endorsement of suicide endangers not only the lives but also the human dignity and quality of support relationships of persons with burdensome infirmities*."

Kevin Yuill



History lecturer Kevin Yuill writes *I'm an atheist and a liberal. I support abortion rights. You might think that would make me supportive of assisted suicide. Anyone who looks closely and critically at the issue will see past the emotive stories and simplistic assumptions used to justify the push for legalisation. The most serious case made by advocates for assisted suicide is autonomy. Yet what stands out for this most recent toleration of at least some suicides is the lack of autonomy; to be legitimate, it seems, suicide must be sanctioned by that new priesthood, medical authority.*

Paul Keating



Paul Keating, former Labor Prime Minister, has warned that any law permitting assisted suicide would undermine the "*civilisational ethic that should be at the heart of our secular society". He observes that once such a law is passed "the expectations of patients and families will change. The culture of dying, despite certain and intense resistance, will gradually permeate into our medical, health, social and institutional arrangements. It stands for everything a truly civil society should stand against. A change of this kind will affect our entire community not just a small number of dying patients*."

John Anderson



Former Deputy Prime Minister John Anderson warns that legalising "*euthanasia and assisted suicide sends the message that government-sanctioned death is a legitimate way to address*" problems such as a lack of access to best practice health services in remote communities. "*We open this door at the peril of all future generations as we move one step closer to a heartless and expedient society where everything is expendable, including the lives of all those whom we, others, or even the state deem 'unsatisfactory'*".

Dominic Perrotet



New South Wales Treasurer Dominic Perrotet writes: *Once the threshold is breached – once our community officially says, ''Yes, for some people suicide is OK'' –we're really just quibbling over details. And what about mistakes? Our legal system prizes its cornerstone principle of ''innocent until proven guilty''. And yet, innocent people go to jail. Lawyers, juries, judges, police and witnesses all make mistakes, because no human system of safeguards is infallible.*
So with assisted suicide laws. Doctors will make mistakes. Victims will be pressured. Judgments will be clouded, and among all the

arbitrary rules and safeguards, only one thing is absolutely certain: innocent people will die at the hands of these laws.

Adrian Dabscheck



Palliative medicine consultant, Adrian Dabscheck writes: *I would like to question if the possible consequent good of allowing a highly selected population of privileged people the ability to request and be administered medical assistance in dying is sufficient to overturn millennia of accepted medical practice. Medicine has long been perceived by society to be beneficent and is trusted to avoid actions which would deliberately hasten death. The intent of Palliative Medicine is the relief of pain and suffering, not the taking of life. Should we risk the incremental creep of our values for the sake of a privileged few?*

Ian Haines



Oncologist Ian Haines writes on how while formerly believing that euthanasia was the only humane solution he no longer believes that.

I have received many euthanasia requests from patients and families over my 34 years in full-time oncology practice, some very passionate, but I have invariably found that they quickly disappear as reassurance and adequate medication doses provide the comfort that is desired and the newly exposed opportunities for patients and families to share deep and poignant moments of bonding and reflection, or nurse a new-born grandchild, or attend a wedding or a graduation.

American College of Physicians

The American College of Physicians is the largest medical specialty organization in the United States with members in more than 145 countries worldwide In 2017 it updated its position on assisted suicide. *Legalization of physician-assisted suicide also raises social justice issues. Society and the medical profession have duties to safeguard the patient–physician relationship and human dignity. These duties apply especially to the most vulnerable members of society: the sick, the elderly, children, the disabled, the poor, minorities, and others. Some individuals might view themselves as unproductive or burdensome and, on that basis, as candidates for assisted suicide, especially if a physician raises it or validates a request.*

World Medical Association



*Physicians-assisted suicide, like euthanasia, is unethical and must be condemned by the medical profession. Where the assistance of the physician is intentionally and deliberately directed at enabling an individual to end his or her own life, the physician acts unethically**.** The World Medical Association strongly encourages all National Medical Associations and physicians to refrain from participating in euthanasia, even if national law allows it or decriminalizes it under certain conditions.*